

IRB-Ready Protocol Template: Studies of Hackles Teaching and Teacher Preparation

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]



OCTOBER 2026

© 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials CC BY-NC 4.0. The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]

A fill-in template for an institutional review board (IRB) submission. It is written to support a minimal-risk, privacy-by-design study. Square brackets mean "fill in" or "decide with your IRB." Anything marked [VERIFY] or [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] needs a primary-source check or legal review. This template is educational guidance, not legal advice and not an IRB determination. Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled trial and has not been approved by any agency; the protocol must say so.

No student accounts, no student data collected, ever. In this template no student identifier, student-level record or student free text ever reaches the research team.

How to use this template

1. Choose a design from the Study Design Menu and delete the sections you do not need.
2. Replace every bracket. Keep the plain-language style.
3. Attach the instruments (Instruments and Codebook), the consent and assent forms (Section 10), the data management plan (Section 8), and the preregistration.
4. Ask your IRB which pathway applies: not human subjects research, exempt, expedited or full board. This template does not decide that [IRB TO DETERMINE].

01 Title, personnel and conflicts

ITEM	ENTRY
Title	[Study of ... in a teacher-preparation course ... / K-12 classes]
Principal investigator	[NAME, ROLE, DEPARTMENT, CITI or equivalent training date]
Co-investigators and analysts	[NAMES]
Independent data custodian	[NAME. Required if the PI teaches or grades the participants]
Funding	[SOURCE or none]
Conflicts of interest	[Declare any connection to the Hackles team, authorship of the kit or course, and any financial interest. State how it is managed: for example, independent analysis, preregistration, and a right to publish regardless of result]

02 Purpose and background

Purpose. [One paragraph: what you want to learn, for whom, and why it matters.]

Background (use the evidence brief). Hackles is a free, skills-based online safety teaching kit with a teacher course. **No controlled trial of Hackles exists.** The kit draws on prevention science about active, repeated, skill-based teaching, much of it from an adjacent field. The kit's own surveys measure knowledge, skills and confidence and have no reported validity evidence. This study [describes implementation and teacher outcomes / estimates a change in survey answers with a comparison group]. It cannot show that Hackles prevents harm. [Cite the "What Is Known and Not Known" brief.]

Research questions.

1. [Example: Do teacher candidates' confidence and observed skill rise between the start and end of the course?]
2. [Example: Did Tell-Readiness, as reported in class tallies, rise more in classes taught first than in delayed classes?]
3. [Example: What helped or got in the way for candidates, instructors and mentors?]

03 Design

[Choose and describe: pre/post with comparison group, stepped wedge, qualitative case study, teacher-implementation study.] State the timeline, the number of sites, classes and participants, and the primary outcome. Refer to the preregistration.

04 Participants and recruitment

GROUP	WHO	HOW MANY	HOW RECRUITED	CONSENT NEEDED
Teacher candidates and teachers	Adults in the course, workshop or PD	[N]	An independent person invites them in person or by email; the instructor does not recruit and does not know who agreed until grades are posted [IRB TO CONFIRM]	Adult consent (Section 10.1)
Mentor teachers, instructors, counselor partners	Adults	[N]	Email from the independent person	Adult consent
K-12 students	Only through aggregate class tallies produced by the teacher as part of ordinary instruction	[classes], about [N] students	The teacher agrees to share class tallies; no student is recruited by the researchers	See Sections 10.2 to 10.5 [IRB TO DETERMINE]

Inclusion. Adults 18 or older enrolled in the course or PD, or teaching a participating class. **Exclusion.** None for adults other than inability to consent. **Students.** Not enrolled as participants in the privacy-by-design option. K-2 students are not part of any research data collection.

Voluntariness. Participation is voluntary. Declining or withdrawing has no effect on grades, evaluations, placement or employment. Participation is not rewarded with grade points [IRB TO CONFIRM; small thank-you gifts may be allowed].

05 **Risk level and minimal-risk justification**

Proposed level: minimal risk [IRB TO DETERMINE]. Probability and magnitude of harm are no greater than those encountered in everyday life or routine classroom activity, because:

- Adults complete a short confidence survey of the kind already in the Academy. No question asks about personal experiences, mental health or trauma history.
- Student surveys are routine classroom check-ins (knowledge, skills, confidence) that teachers already use. The research team sees only class-level counts.
- There are no recordings of students, no student names, codes or free text in the research data, and no intervention beyond the teacher's usual lesson.
- Any small group (fewer than 10) is suppressed [VERIFY your district's rule].

Risks and mitigations.

RISK	MITIGATION
Distress in adults from the topic	Content note; optional questions; counselor partner and counseling center numbers on every form; right to stop
Coercion or undue influence on candidates	Independent recruiter; no grade link; data released after grades; instructor not told who participates
Privacy breach of survey data	Minimal data; no names; secure storage; destruction schedule (Section 8)
Re-identification of a class or teacher	Study codes; suppression; report pooled results; no school or teacher names in publications unless agreed in writing
A student's disclosure surfacing in an open answer	The research team never sees open answers; teachers read them the same day and follow the Disclosure and Incident Guide and school policy (Section 11)
Harm to students from the research	None beyond usual instruction; the delayed-start design gives every class the lessons
Overstating results	Preregistration; limits statement; no effectiveness claims

Benefits. Direct benefit to teachers: information about their own confidence and skill. Indirect: knowledge about implementation. No direct benefit is promised to students.

06 Procedures and timeline

[Table: week or term, what happens, who does it. Example below.]

WHEN	WHAT	WHO
Before term	IRB approval; independent custodian set up; preregistration filed	PI
Week 1	Independent person invites candidates; consent; Pre-Course Confidence Survey (paper or secure form)	Independent person; candidates
Weeks 1 to 13	Course as usual. Optional: peer-observed micro-teach and practicum scores are shared with the independent custodian with consent	Instructor; custodian
Week 13	Post-Course Confidence Survey	Candidates
Week 0 and 11 (K-12)	Teachers give the student survey as ordinary practice and send the class tally sheet (counts only) to the custodian	Teachers
After grades	Custodian sends the de-identified file to the analyst	Custodian

07 Instruments

LIST THE INSTRUMENTS BY ID from the Instruments and Codebook file (R1 to R8), say which you will use, and attach them unchanged. If you adapt any item, say so and label it "adapted from the Hackles Assessment Pack." No instrument asks about a student's own experiences, sex behavior or attitudes, illegal or demeaning behavior, mental or psychological problems, family relationships, religion, politics or income.

08 Privacy by design and data management plan

Principles. (1) No student identifiers in research data. (2) The unit of analysis for students is the class, using **aggregate teacher tallies**. (3) Collect the minimum. (4) Keep the code key, if any, with the teacher or the independent custodian, never with the analyst. (5) Destroy what you do not need.

DATA	FORMAT	HELD BY	WHERE	WHO HAS ACCESS	RETENTION	DESTRUCTION
Consent forms (adults)	Paper or encrypted PDF	Independent custodian	Locked cabinet or encrypted institutional storage	Custodian, PI (consent status only after grades)	[per IRB, for example 3 years after study end]	Shred or secure delete
Candidate survey responses	Encrypted spreadsheet	Custodian	Institutional encrypted drive	Custodian; analyst gets a de-identified file after grades	[per IRB]	Secure delete

DATA	FORMAT	HELD BY	WHERE	WHO HAS ACCESS	RETENTION	DESTRUCTION
Student paper surveys	Paper	Teacher	Teacher's locked storage	Teacher only	Per district policy [VERIFY]	Per district policy
Class tallies	CSV with study codes	Teacher, then custodian	Institutional encrypted drive	Custodian, analyst	[per IRB]	Secure delete
Linking key (candidate IDs to study codes)	Separate encrypted file	Custodian	Separate location from data	Custodian only	Until grades are posted and data are verified, then destroy	Secure delete
Analysis code and synthetic test data	Text files	PI	Repository	Public if agreed	Indefinite	n/a
Observer forms and recordings	Paper; audio (optional, with consent)	Instructor or custodian	Locked or encrypted	Instructor for scoring only	Until scored	Delete at term end

Security. Encryption at rest and in transit; institution-approved storage only; no personal email or consumer cloud accounts; no data on removable media. Report any breach to the IRB and the institution's privacy office promptly [IRB TO SET TIMELINE].

Suppression. Report no group under 10 students. Report no class alone unless the teacher and school agree in writing.

Student data. The research team does not collect student names, student codes, dates of birth, photos, audio, video, free text, IEP or 504 status, or demographic data. If the study needs subgroup analysis by demographic characteristics, the teacher may provide aggregate counts only, with suppression, after review [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM FERPA implications].

Data sharing. Share only aggregated, suppressed, de-identified class-level files and the code, under the terms in the Publication, Authorship and Data Licence Policy. Say this in the consent form.

09 Compensation

[None / a small thank-you not tied to grades.]

10 Consent, permission and assent

10.1 ADULT CONSENT (TEACHER CANDIDATES, TEACHERS, MENTORS, INSTRUCTORS, COUNSELOR PARTNERS)

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
Consent to take part in a research study Study: [TITLE]. Researcher: [NAME, institution, contact]. Independent contact: [NAME, contact]. What is this study? We are studying [what]. This is research. The Hackles kit has not been tested in a controlled trial and has not been approved by any agency. We cannot tell you it works. We want to learn [what]. Why you? You are [a candidate in this course / a teacher using Hackles lessons]. What would you do? [Complete a 10-minute survey twice. Allow your micro-teach and practicum scores to be shared with the independent data custodian. (Optional) Be interviewed for 30 to 45 minutes.] Nothing asks about your personal experiences or history. Is it voluntary? Yes. Saying no or stopping has no effect on your grade, evaluation, placement or job. [Your instructor will not know whether you take part until after grades are posted.] You may skip any question. Risks and benefits. Some questions may feel uncomfortable because the topic is child safety. You may stop at any time. If you want to talk with someone, call [counseling center] or call or text 988. The main benefit is learning about your own confidence. We cannot promise any benefit. Privacy. We will not use your name in any report. An independent person keeps the key linking your name to your answers, and destroys it after grades are posted and data are checked. We will share only combined results. Limits to confidentiality. If you tell us that a child is being harmed or is at risk of harm, researchers who are mandated reporters may be required to report it [VERIFY your state and institution]. We will tell you if we must. We cannot promise confidentiality in that case. Questions. [Contact]. For questions about your rights as a participant, contact the IRB at [contact]. Your choice. I have read this form (or it was read to me). I agree to take part: Yes / No. Signature: _____ Date: _____. [Optional separate checkboxes: I agree to audio recording of my interview; I agree that my de-identified, combined results may be shared with other researchers.]	

10.2 PARENTAL PERMISSION AND STUDENT ASSENT: ONLY IF A DESIGN COLLECTS STUDENT-LEVEL DATA OR ADMINISTERS A RESEARCH-ONLY SURVEY

THE PRIVACY-BY-DESIGN OPTION AVOIDS these forms because researchers receive only class tallies from routine instruction. If your IRB, district or counsel decides that any student-level data or research-specific survey is involved, use permission and assent. A survey on any PPRA protected area, given by a school official, needs prior written parental consent that cannot be replaced by an opt-out; the Assessment Pack reports a US Department of Education letter of Aug. 26, 2026 saying so [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in the kit; confirm the letter itself with counsel]. The templates below are for knowledge, skills and confidence items only.

10.3 PARENT OR GUARDIAN PERMISSION (GRADES 3-12)

FIELD NOTE	No. 2
Permission for your child's class results to be included in a study Dear family: [Teacher] teaches online safety lessons using a free kit called Hackles. [Researcher, institution] is studying [what]. The lessons are skills-based and avoid graphic detail. We collect no student accounts or data. What this means for your child. Your child will do the same short classroom survey that the teacher gives to the whole class. It asks what children know, can do and feel confident about. It does not ask about your child's own experiences. The teacher counts the answers for the whole class. The researchers see only class totals, never your child's name or answers. [If student-level data are used: The researchers will see answers linked to a code, never a name.] Is it voluntary? Yes. Your child will still do the lessons and the classroom survey as usual. If you say no, [the teacher will not include your child's survey in the class counts that are sent to the researchers]. There is no penalty. Questions or to opt out: [teacher/contact]. You may review the survey and the lesson materials at any time. [Reply slip: I give permission / I do not give permission. Parent name and signature.] [Provide in the family's language where possible; do not use a child as interpreter.]	

10.4 STUDENT ASSENT (AGES 8 TO 12)

FIELD NOTE	No. 3
We are learning how well these lessons help kids know what to do online. You will take the same short survey as your classmates. It is not a test. There are no grades, and you can skip any question. Your teacher will add up the whole class's answers. The researchers will not see your name. You can say "no thanks" and nothing bad will happen. If anything in the survey worries you, tell your teacher or the school counselor. Circle: Yes, you can include my answers. No thanks.	

10.5 STUDENT ASSENT (AGES 13 TO 17)

FIELD NOTE	No. 4
This study is looking at whether online safety lessons change what students know and feel able to do. You will take the same short survey that your class takes. It does not ask about your own experiences. The researchers see class totals, not your name. Taking part is voluntary and does not affect your grade. You can skip any question or stop. If a question upsets you, tell a teacher or counselor. Call or text 988 if you are in distress. Do you agree to have your answers included? Yes / No.	

Waivers. If your IRB considers waiving documentation or parental permission for aggregate, routine-instruction data, document the request and justification [IRB TO DETERMINE].

11 Adverse events, disclosures and distress

Definitions. An *adverse event* is any harm or distress linked to taking part. An *unanticipated problem* is any event that is unexpected, related to the research and suggests greater risk than thought. A *disclosure* is a statement that a child is being harmed, is at risk, or has harmed someone.

What the research team never receives. Student free text, individual student surveys, or any information identifying a student.

If a student's answer suggests harm (teacher's duty, not the research team's). The teacher reads open answers the same day. If anything suggests that a student is being harmed or is at risk, the teacher follows the Disclosure and Incident Guide and the school's policy: First 10 Minutes, report personally and promptly as the law and policy require, notify the administrator and counselor, document. The teacher does not wait for research results. **Even anonymous surveys can reveal identity by handwriting or detail.** Treat concerning content as a disclosure. The research protocol never delays or replaces a report.

If an adult participant becomes distressed. Offer to pause or stop. Provide the counseling center number and 988 (call or text) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 988lifeline.org]. The counselor partner is available for any session where hard content is discussed. Do not probe.

If an adult participant discloses something that suggests a child is at risk. Do not promise confidentiality. Say what you must do and why. Report as required by law and policy [VERIFY; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM], then tell the IRB if the event is related to the research.

Reporting. Report unanticipated problems and serious adverse events to the IRB within [IRB TO SET, for example 5 working days]. Keep a log without identifiers.

Stopping rules. The PI will pause the study if a participant's distress is serious, if a breach occurs, or if the independent custodian reports undue influence.

12 Mandated-reporter obligations of researchers

- Check whether you are a mandated reporter in your state, through your employment, your licensure or because everyone is a reporter in your state [VERIFY: Child Welfare Information Gateway summary, current through May 2023, and your state's current statute]. Researchers with teaching licenses, counseling licenses or school employment are often covered.
- Say in every consent form that confidentiality has limits when a child may be at risk.
- Know your reporting route (CPS or law enforcement, and for online exploitation the NCMEC CyberTipline, report.cybertip.org, 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05]). Put it on a card in the research binder.
- A research design that avoids contact with student-level information reduces the chance of a disclosure reaching the team, but does not remove the duty if one does.
- Do not investigate, confront anyone, view images or ask a participant to produce any message or picture. Do not promise secrecy.
- The Disclosure and Incident Guide applies to researchers who meet a child in the field. Researchers should not be alone with a child.
- A federal Certificate of Confidentiality does not replace the duty to report suspected child abuse where state law requires it, and it may not apply to your study [VERIFY with your IRB and funder].

13 **Vulnerable populations and special considerations**

GROUP	CONCERN	HOW THIS PROTOCOL HANDLES IT
Children (under 18)	Additional protections apply to research with minors [VERIFY: 45 CFR 46 Subpart D and state law]	Students are not research participants in the privacy-by-design option; if student-level data are used, permission and assent apply; no K-2 data
Students as subordinates (candidates in the instructor's course)	Power imbalance and perceived pressure	Independent recruiter; no link to grades; the instructor is blind to participation until after grades; participation never affects placement
Teachers as employees of a district	Pressure from administrators	Written voluntary participation; no supervisor access to individual data
Adults with a personal history of harm	The topic may touch real life	Content note; no questions about experiences; counselor partner; right to skip or stop
English learners and families who speak another language	Understanding consent	Translations by qualified translators [VERIFY]; interpreter for meetings; no child as interpreter
Students with disabilities	Access to the survey	Surveys may be read aloud; extra time and accommodations are always allowed [VERIFY IEP and 504 accommodations]; do not collect disability status
Children in foster care or wards of the state	Special permission rules may apply [VERIFY 45 CFR 46 Subpart D and state rules]	Do not recruit these children individually; aggregate class tallies only
Children who may be at risk at home	A survey could prompt a disclosure	Teacher reads open answers the same day and follows the Disclosure Guide; counselor aware on survey days
Small schools and classes	Re-identification risk	Suppression under 10; pooled reporting; no school names without written agreement

14 **Legal and policy references (all [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM])**

45 CFR 46 (Common Rule) [VERIFY]; FERPA, 20 U.S.C. 1232g and 34 CFR Part 99 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 for the school-official exception in the kit; confirm research provisions]; PPRA, 20 U.S.C. 1232h [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in the kit]; COPPA, 16 CFR Part 312 and the 2025 amendments (compliance April 22, 2026) [VERIFIED 2026-10-05 in the kit]; state student-privacy laws and your district's research policy. See the PPRA, FERPA and COPPA checklist.

15 **Dissemination**

[Where you will publish or present.] Results will be reported in aggregate with limits stated. See the Publication, Authorship and Data Licence Policy for authorship, the courtesy review by the Hackles team of factual descriptions of the kit, and licensing of instruments and data.

16 Attachments checklist

- ☐ Preregistration
- ☐ Consent form for adults
- ☐ Parental permission and student assent (if applicable)
- ☐ Instruments (R1 to R8 as used) and codebook
- ☐ Data management plan (Section 8)
- ☐ Recruitment script from the independent person
- ☐ Teacher agreement to share class tallies
- ☐ Site letters of support from administrators [VERIFY district research-approval process]
- ☐ Counselor partner agreement
- ☐ Training certificates (human subjects; mandated-reporter orientation)
- ☐ Limits statement text

This template is educational guidance, not legal advice and not an IRB determination.